THE NEW OLD PLACE

Fujas and Phillips discover the best part of Austria's Dachstein Glacier

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Real Estate

The town of Obertraun has likely been there for hundreds of years; the mountains now called "Krippenstein" likely climbed, explored, and skied for most of the last century. But Pep Fujas and Bryce Phillips had no idea the place existed before last March, when they came, ripped, and seriously considered buying real estate.

The Spread (or, what limitless access to the Austrian Alps looks like)

Perched above Obertraun, Krippenstein lies atop a series of jagged, north-facing walls that stack up to comprise a small side-section of the Dachstein Masiff. This craggy rock formation flattens out into a giant moonscaped glacier. With a pair of skins and a lot of time on your hands you could hop off the upper tram, start poling south, and ski a decent chunk of Austria.

The resort's trail map makes it appear that the mountains get higher and higher, but it's misleading. This is a glacier, and the layout doesn't crawl up, it sprawls away. If you traversed all the way to the top of the map, you could drop into the town of Annaberg, where Fujas found the rail he's sliding on page 53.

"The locals kept telling us that if we just had a helicopter, we'd be blown away by the mountains," says Phillips. "We didn't need a heli to be blown away, but it would have been sick to get back there farther and explore. Every year a new spot like this sort of pops up in Austria or somewhere else in Europe, but for some reason the story never gets completely told. Krippenstein is still off the beaten path and under the radar."

When Bryce isn't fufilling his photo requirements for K2, he's an online retail magnate managing millions. This makes him similar to Olympic mogul champion Dale Begg-Smith, only without the salty attitude.

Of course, Bryce doesn't have a signature ski like Pep does. So, they're kind of even in the overall scheme of things.

The Skiing (or, why you should skip the rest of Austria and just come here)

The ski area's management has slowly warmed up to the idea that their terrain offers big mountain and mini-golf-style lines that compare to better-known resorts in Switzerland and France. Of course, the locals have always known this, and wish the management would just shut up.

The terrain offers so much, in fact, that the crew had trouble getting around. Look carefully at some of these pictures and you'll see tracks laid by the other skier just before the shot was taken.

"It's funny," says Abbott, "athletes travel thousands of miles to ride these incredible mountains. But when they're making magazines or movies, the shot's the most important thing, and a place like Krippenstein is so diverse, they probably shot ten to fifteen lines within 200 yards of each other."

Then again, as cool as the Fujative is, it's not worth millions of dollars, like Bryce's website.

The Rocks (or, why you shouldn't do what these guys did)

The geology around Krippenstein is unique. The tram ascends 4,000 feet straight up from Obertraun to access the snow, while an incredibly deep lake lies just on the other side of town. It's such a sheer drop-off from peak to valley that all the roads require heavy-duty shelters to protect them from rock slides and avalanches. And while skiers are just getting hip to the place, spelunkers have been coming for years—two of the longest explored caves in the world run under the glacier.

"Krippenstein has some really good skiers—our guide charged almost every line we shot," explains Fujas. "But the majority of them don't trust themselves. I think it has something to do with the type of rock that forms the mountain. It's like Swiss cheese. There are huge holes in the ground all over the place and sometimes people just … disappear. And the only warnings we ever saw were posted by other skiers—not the ski patrol. So everyone's really cautious. When we were riding down to one cliff, an Austrian dude followed us but got that 'Shit, this is a really bad idea' look once we were on top. Maybe he knew something we didn't."

Over the course of the trip, the conditions and visibility got progressively worse. By the end, Abbott was marking off his shooting positions by pouring Gatorade in the snow, so he wouldn't step off and into a crevasse.

The Down Day (or, how to entertain yourself in an Austrian white-out)

Tipped off by a pair of supremely stoked Austrian kids (visible in the upper left of the rail photo) who recognized Fujas from the posters on their walls, Fujas made the trek to Annaberg once the weather became unshootable. He found the rail—longer, steeper, and higher off the ground than he hoped—at the base of a small resort's lifts. The maintainance crew working on the lifts didn't pay any attention, so Fujas got to work greasing the rail.

Thus inspired, one of the locals clicked in and stepped up, caught an edge, somersaulted over the rail, and slammed head-first into the steel cheesegrater stairs. Miraculously unhurt beyond a few small cuts, the local claimed it was all worth it for the high-five his American freeskiing hero gave him for his efforts.

The resort's maintainance crew then decided to take issue with the now-damaged piece of resort property and demanded 1,000 euros to go away. While Fujas feigned ignorance, the German-speaking cinematographer that was shooting engaged in some haggling and talked them down to 250 of his own hard-earned Euros. The lesson? Don't learn a lick of German. Ever.

The Nightlife (or, rather, the lack thereof)

"Obertraum is like three blocks long," says Fujas, "and the little bar in the middle of town is only open on Thursdays, Fridays, Saturdays, and Sundays. It was dead empty every time we went. They also have this weird Euro bowling-type place. You only have to knock down five or seven pins, and they're all attached to strings. You huck these little bowling balls at them, and they pop right back up. It was a pretty even game—Bryce won a few, Nate won a few, and I won a few. It was all tied up when it started to get really, really boring."

The Conclusion (or, the end)

Come to Krippenstein if you want untracked lines with limitless possibility and zero nightlife. Be very wary of the large holes in the mountains. And, if you plan on taking pictures, bring some Gatorade to mark off your shooting position so you don't fall into a crevasse.

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If Pep had millions of dollars, he would have laughed when the resort employees busted him for hitting this rail and loudly declared, "I'm buying this whole place! You're fired!" Unfortunately, Bryce wasn't around, so they had to figure something else out.